
FROM SIBLING RIVALRY TO FRIENDS AND CONFIDANTS

Lesson Three

Show Up on Purpose

What to actually do: open conversation, intentional interaction, and clear boundaries.

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Before we start

Lesson One was about reading your children. Lesson Two was about reading yourself. This one is about what you actually do, day to day, once you've done both.

A lot of well-meaning parenting advice stops at insight: understand the feeling, watch your tone, and the rest will sort itself out. It won't, not on its own. Understanding without action just becomes guilt with better vocabulary. This lesson is the doing part: three ordinary habits that, practised consistently, quietly change what siblings expect from each other and from you.

Why this matters more than it seems to

The research on what actually helps sibling relationships is refreshingly practical: it doesn't ask parents to become therapists, just to be a bit more present and a bit more consistent. One randomised trial of a brief parenting programme found that families saw improvements across almost every measure (conflict, warmth, children's emotional and behavioural problems, and parents' own confidence) after a short structured intervention. The gains weren't dramatic, but they were real, and they point to something reassuring: you don't need to overhaul your parenting to move the needle. Small, consistent moves matter.

What tends to make things worse is also well documented, and it's almost the mirror image of what helps: sibling conflict and bullying rise when children are left to sort things out entirely on their own, or punished simply for fighting, with no one helping them find another way through. In other words, hands-off and heavy-handed both backfire, for different reasons, but just as reliably.

The common thread through the research on what works is parents staying actively, warmly involved. Not refereeing every squabble, but not disappearing from the relationship either. Being the steady adult who's still in the room.

There's a second finding worth knowing if there's a co-parent, ex-partner, or another caregiver in the picture: parents who feel supported by a co-parent (someone they can compare notes with, lean on, or simply not do this alone) are more likely to choose calmer, more constructive responses to sibling conflict. Alignment isn't just nice to have. It's protective, for you as much as for them.

Three habits worth building

None of these require a big, dramatic shift, just doing something on purpose that might otherwise be left to chance.

1. Open

This means conversation about the sibling relationship isn't reserved only for when something's gone wrong. A quick, low-stakes check-in, "how's it going with your brother lately?", asked on an ordinary day, tells a child that you're interested in the relationship itself, not just in policing the fallout when it goes sideways.

2. Intentional

Closeness between siblings doesn't reliably happen by accident, especially once rivalry has a foothold. It helps to engineer small moments of shared positive experience (a game, a task, a walk) on purpose, rather than hoping proximity alone will do the work. This is exactly what the evidence-based programmes lean on: actively teaching and encouraging warmth between siblings, not just managing the conflict when it shows up.

3. Boundaries

This is the piece easy to get backwards. The boundary isn't between feeling and not feeling; every feeling is allowed. The boundary is between feeling and doing. "You're allowed to be furious. You're not allowed to hit." Held together, calmly, every time, this teaches a child that big emotions don't make them bad, and that limits aren't a withdrawal of love.

The three habits at a glance

Habit	What it means	What it sounds like
Open	A regular, low-key check-in that isn't only about conflict, so talking to you doesn't only happen when something's gone wrong.	"How are things between you two lately?" Asked on an ordinary Tuesday, not just after a fight.

Habit	What it means	What it sounds like
Intentional	Small, engineered moments of connection between siblings that you set up on purpose, rather than hoping closeness happens on its own.	Ten minutes of a shared activity most kids enjoy together, a few times a week, not left to chance.
Boundaries	A clear, calmly held line between what's allowed to be felt and what's allowed to be done, held at the same time, not traded off against each other.	"You're allowed to be furious with your brother. You're not allowed to hit him. Let's sort out the furious part."

The language that makes the difference

The way you step into a conflict shapes what your children learn to expect from you, and from each other, the next time one starts.

Instead of...	Try...
<i>"Sort it out yourselves, I'm not getting involved."</i>	"I'm going to help you both find a way through this. You don't have to sort this alone."
<i>"I don't care who started it, you're both in trouble."</i>	"Let's figure out what happened, one at a time. I want to understand both sides."
<i>"Stop fighting or no one gets [x]."</i>	"You're both allowed to be upset. Hitting isn't allowed. Let's cool down, then talk."
<i>"Your dad/mum said you could, I'm not going to be the bad guy."</i>	(Retire this one too. Sort the difference out together, out of earshot, so the boundary holds either way.)

Bringing it back to Name It, Ground It, Talk It

This lesson is where the tool leaves the quiet, one-on-one moment and becomes part of daily life. Open conversation makes Name It a habit rather than a rescue. Intentional connection makes Ground It something siblings eventually do with each other, not just with you. And clear boundaries make Talk It safe, because a child only talks honestly when they trust the limits are steady, fair, and never used as punishment for the feeling itself.

Showing up on purpose doesn't mean showing up perfectly. It means being the steady, predictable adult in the room often enough that your children start to believe conflict is something that gets worked through, not something to fear or hide.